

From Outline to Story

A practical next step after students finish the seven StoryDogs stages

Read the outline aloud before adding more words. Can students explain how one event leads to the next? Fix one confusing jump together, then choose a way to tell the story.

K–2 Draw and tell

Make a picture story using the seven steps as a guide. Students can draw each event and dictate a sentence for an adult to write underneath. If seven pictures feel like too much, start with the beginning, biggest problem, and ending. Talk through the connecting events.

Say: “Show me what is happening in this picture. What should I write so someone else understands?”

Grades 3–4 Make a comic or short story

Use the steps as comic panels or a plan for a short story. Add speech bubbles, actions, and a few details that help a reader picture the setting. One step can take several panels or paragraphs. Ask students to expand a favorite moment first.

Say: “Your outline says the plan went wrong. Show us what the character tried and what happened.”

Grades 5–6 Build scenes or chapters

Choose a moment to write as a scene: the character wants something, tries to get it, and meets a problem or makes a choice. Add dialogue, thoughts, and actions. Connect scenes into a short story or chapters when the idea needs more space. Seven steps do not require seven chapters.

Say: “What does your character do next, and why? What can readers see or hear in this moment?”

A messy first draft is doing its job

The first draft helps writers discover the story. Crossed-out words, new ideas, and changed endings are useful. Say, “Get the story down. We can help the reader follow it afterward.” Save spelling and punctuation fixes for a later pass unless they block meaning.

Give feedback that helps the next draft

Ask a partner to name one moment they could picture and one place they wanted to know more. Then choose one revision: connect a confusing event, expand the climax, or show the character’s change through an action.

A simple closing invitation: “Read us the part you’re glad you wrote.” Sharing a picture or a few lines counts, too.